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Special session 1B: How can society be improved through peace innovation? (Tuesday 14:10-15:40)

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Description

Today, we find ourselves in a global situation where conflicts within and between countries are increasing, or at least becoming more apparent and having greater consequences than just a decade ago. Military build-up and increased policing are current responses to the rising violence in these situations. We argue that humanity lacks much-needed knowledge about the crucial factors when societal climates deteriorate. While external factors like resource scarcity, limited freedoms, and reduced influence are recognized as triggers for negative reactions, comprehending how societal climates shift, even in relatively prosperous environments, remains a challenge. We want to investigate and discuss whether peace innovation is a missing research area that has the potential to contribute to increased global peace and fewer conflicts in society. We see this research field as interdisciplinary but emerging from a technical perspective, meaning that we incorporate technology and disruptive new technological areas as means to achieve our goals.

We envision opportunities to strengthen innovation processes that enhance understanding among people and improve communication capabilities and increase empathy among different groups and cultures. Inspired by initiatives such as Stanford's Peace Innovation Lab (https://www.peaceinnovation.stanford.edu/), a center aiming at creating technology that systematically augments our ability to engage positively with each other, we see this conference as a unique opportunity to discuss what establishing such a field would entail. We would love to run a 2-hour workshop aims to familiarize participants with the concept of peace innovation and explore strategies for promoting positive engagement across diverse boundaries. The agenda includes an introductory session, an icebreaker activity focusing on group identity mapping, an interactive exercise simulating interactions (based on contact theory principles), a brainstorming session on Peace Tech/innovation interventions, and a closing discussion on how to collaborate to contribute to the planned special issue.